

create specific exceptions. Avoid solving one broken website by allowing third-party cookies everywhere.

In Safari on macOS, open Safari > Settings > Privacy and enable Prevent cross-site tracking. Apple says Safari can periodically delete tracking data from third-party content providers and block tracking through embedded social buttons. Review the Privacy Report to see encountered trackers.

Brave's Shields block trackers, cross-site cookie tracking and fingerprinting by default. Keep the default protection unless a site fails, then lower protection for that site rather than globally. Brave retired its older strict fingerprinting mode after finding that the extra breakage outweighed its usefulness for most users.

Step 3: Control permissions and automatic identification

Open the browser's site-settings panel and review Location, Camera, Microphone, Notifications, Clipboard, Pop-ups and Automatic Downloads. Change sensitive permissions to Ask or Block by default. Remove permissions granted to sites you no longer use. Chrome provides central site controls for reviewing and changing these permissions.

Disable automatic sign-in where it creates identity cross-over. Before selecting "Continue with Google", "Continue with Apple" or another identity provider, confirm that the account belongs to the correct compartment. A convenient federated login can create a durable bridge between the new service and an established identity.

Review address and payment autofill. Saving information may be appropriate in a financial profile but dangerous in a public or exploratory profile, where one mistaken click can reveal a legal name, home address or cardholder details.

Step 4: Keep extensions few and deliberate

Extensions can block trackers or improve usability, but they also become part of the browser's attack surface and configuration. Some can read or alter content across every visited website. Chrome warns that extensions granted access to site data may read, request or modify information on the pages a user visits.

Install only extensions with a clear purpose, reputable publisher and permissions you understand. Mozilla similarly recommends reviewing what data and browser features an extension requests before accepting it. Do not build a "privacy browser" from fifteen obscure add-ons.

Audit extensions every three months:

1. Remove anything unused.
2. Recheck requested permissions.
3. Confirm that updates come from the official store.
4. Avoid duplicate tools performing the same job.
5. Disable an extension temporarily when diagnosing breakage.

PRACTICAL BROWSING ROUTINE

Before opening a site, choose the correct browser profile. Check whether you actually need to log in. Decline non-essential notification, location and contact requests. Prefer the browser's built-in tracking protection, keep extensions minimal and remove site-specific exceptions after use. Clean tracking parameters from links before sharing when doing so does not damage the destination. Avoid posting the same material from different identity compartments in immediate succession.

6. Never install an extension because a random page claims it is required.

Step 5: Clear data with a purpose

Deleting all browser data every day can log you out, remove preferences and create needless work. A more sustainable approach is to isolate cookies, block known trackers and clear data selectively.

After visiting a low-trust site, open the browser's site-data controls and delete that domain's cookies and storage. Clear the entire browsing history when local privacy requires it, such as before returning a borrowed computer. Remember that clearing local history does not erase records held by the website, search provider, employer or internet provider.

Treat exceptions as temporary. When a bank, payment gateway or embedded form fails:

1. Confirm the address is genuine.
2. Disable protection only for that site.
3. Complete the required task.
4. Restore protection.
5. Remove the exception if it is no longer needed.
6. Check whether the activity belongs in a dedicated profile.

Step 6: Test what the browser reveals

Run the Electronic Frontier Foundation's Cover Your Tracks test in each major browser profile. It reports whether the browser blocks tracking advertisements and invisible trackers, and whether its configuration appears resistant to fingerprinting. EFF cautions that the test does not measure every tracking technique, so use it as a comparison tool rather than a certificate of anonymity.

Record the result, change one setting and test again. If you change five things simultaneously, you will not know which one improved privacy or caused breakage. Also compare logged-out and logged-in sessions. The difference demonstrates why direct account identity can matter more than a tracker score. **d**